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Review

Reviewed Work(s): Talking About Machines: An Ethnography of a Modern Job. by Julian E. Orr

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Source: *The Journal of the Royal Anthropological Institute*, Vol. 4, No. 2 (Jun., 1998), pp. 360-361

Published by: Wiley on behalf of Royal Anthropological Institute of Great Britain and Ireland

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/3034516>

Accessed: 13-03-2025 00:04 UTC

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one of the most important levels of analysis in the book; from the deconstruction of the neat distinction between foreign-owned and locally owned companies to the demonstration of the link between 'global' products such as Coca-Cola and Kentucky Fried Chicken, and local identity. Another main concern, familiar from Miller's earlier work, is a re-evaluation of the role of the consumer, from a relatively passive 'chooser' to an active 'shaper' of commodities, although it must be said that he takes pains to avoid a simple voluntarism. Related with this perspective is the analysis of the symbolic contexts for the production of commodities, ethnographically focused on non-alcoholic beverages (an important category of symbolically loaded commodities in tropical Trinidad). Finally, and this is the aspect most relevant for an evaluation of the significance of ethnography for academic economics, Miller argues that there is a profound difference between what he calls 'organic capitalism' and 'pure capitalism'. The former is the very texture of Trinidadian society, where opposition to capitalism has been negligible compared to European societies; profit-seeking economic activity enmeshed in ethnic relationships, politics, identity issues and national concerns. Indeed, an important point for Miller is the fact that Trinidad as a context cannot be separated from Trinidadian capitalism, since the former is to a great extent generated by the latter. 'Pure capitalism' is the application of abstract economic models to Trinidadian society championed by the IMF and manifest in the 'structural adjustment programmes' evident in Trinidad since the late 1980s, and which Miller describes as 'bad capitalism' because it fails to articulate with local concerns.

The great strength of this monograph lies in its integration of minute detail and grand theoretical issues, and together with *Modernity: an ethnographic approach*, it is a highly original contribution both to the comparative analysis of modernity and to Caribbean ethnography. Irreverent and daring, Miller continuously prods the reader to re-think deeply ingrained assumptions, not least widespread among anthropologists, about the relationship between capitalism and society. At times the author may seem over-ambitious in his aims; occasionally the level of analysis is unclear (he shifts between global capitalism, local capitalism, enterprises, their employees, retailers and ordinary consumers), but, on the whole, the book is impressive, a major achievement by one of the most exciting anthropologists writing today. The most important lesson to be drawn from the book, pertinent at a time when the future of anthropology seems to be an explicit or implicit item on the agenda of most conferences, is perhaps that the classic anthropological method and form of questioning, which aims at contextualizing life-worlds, can still generate revolutionary insights today, provided they are

raised in the appropriate settings.

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ORR, JULIAN. E. *Talking about machines: an ethnography of a modern job*. xviii, 172 pp., bibliogr. Ithaca, London: Cornell Univ. Press, 1996. £25.50 (cloth), £10.95 (paper)

Information technology and the globalization of trade have changed the world of work profoundly. One result, it is claimed here, is that much work (at least in developed countries) has become invisible. Microelectronics in particular has bred a whole range of occupations where knowledge about the content of the job is largely restricted to its practitioners. Julian Orr's *Talking about machines* is an attempt to uncover what one such job, that of the photocopier repairer, actually entails. It is an ethnographic study focusing on the practice of work rather than on the relationship of employment, and first in a new series aimed at documenting work practices in this new world.

Orr's book is based on a dissertation completed in 1990. A qualified technician, he observed and recorded the work of technicians employed by a company which leased photocopiers to customer companies. Technicians worked individually but were co-ordinated in teams and subteams covering specified geographical areas. There was no career ladder and technicians identified not with their employers but with an 'occupational community' (p. 142) of technicians. This term, in use for some years, describes the close ties which may exist between workers following the same trade, and which form the basis of an occupational culture. Story telling, which plays a significant part in technicians' occupational culture, is the central focus of Orr's analysis.

The book begins, however, with a general discussion of the technician's job. The work has both a social and a technical dimension: technicians must not only fix machines, but also keep customers content. The machine has a role in its own right. Machines come in different types. Not only that, they are differently used and as different parts are replaced each becomes distinctive. Its particular history and characteristics must be considered: it is treated like an individual. In consequence, Orr's analysis is based on the triangular relationship between technician, customer and machine.

Technicians' work is characterized by uncertainty and unpredictability: each day is different. This is represented by a series of five vignettes: a breakfast meeting; a call-out to an older machine; a courtesy call; an informal lunch and consultation with a group of technicians; and a routine service call. The central problem of the job, diagnosing machine faults, is then

discussed in some detail. Service manuals are used but diagnostic skills are crucially based on experiential learning: technicians build up understanding through careful observation of the machines and questioning of users. The custom of retailing to one another stories about their encounters with machines is a further means of sharing information and of learning the art of diagnosis. Such stories, Orr emphasizes, are not just about work, they are an important part of the work process itself. At the same time, story telling serves other functions: it celebrates success and it is a means of competition and an opportunity to achieve 'heroic' status. There is a degree of repetitiveness in the writing, but this may be intentional. For example, fieldwork excerpts which are followed by commentaries may accustom the reader to some of the technical terms. Altogether, the book is a considerable achievement. Data from a technical and, for many, an alien environment are transformed into readable prose and shaped into a persuasive, even elegant, argument. Good books raise questions and this one makes one wonder what else is going on at work. Much has been written about gender and technology, yet there is no indication of its relevance here. More discussion of other work ethnographies would have been welcome, but perhaps this lies outside the scope of such a monograph.

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PLATTNER, STUART. *High art down home: an economic ethnography of a local art market*. xiv, 250 pp., illus., bibliogr. Chicago, London: Univ. of Chicago Press, 1996. £23.95

All too often economic studies of the Western art market focus on its centres of activity, detailing the shifts in price of, say, Old Masters or Abstract Expressionists at Sotheby Parke Bernet or Christie's in London. Plattner bucks this trend, by concentrating on the unexceptional art market of a medium-sized American city, St Louis. What happens there may be unexciting to dedicated voyeurs of the market, but it is potentially far more representative of the market as a whole than the spectacles staged by international auction houses.

The sale of art is a good topic for an anthropologist of Western economics, as price is so independent of the usual variables. What fixes the price is not costs of production, material and labour but a surprisingly broad and seemingly arbitrary range of social and cultural factors. These factors are managed, to varying degrees of success, by artists, collectors, dealers and curators. Together they loosely constitute a bitchy, mutually supportive network, all of them with an unspoken investment in the mystification of value of works of art.

The meat of Plattner's ethnography is three central chapters devoted, respectively, to artists, dealers and collectors. Each chapter comprises a gallery of portraits, in which Plattner, using transcripts of his interviews, allows his chosen characters to speak for themselves. This procedure underlines certain values of his speakers' world, for in the art market individuality is almost all, and a lengthy transcript allows a speaker's cultivated individuality to stand out very clearly: the workaholic monk who runs his own gallery on his Order's grounds and makes so much money that he helps fund his own Order; the idealistic dealer who has found 'The Truth' and wants to save the world with it; the aged collector who has neglected his career for the sake of feeding his obsession.

The collapse of hegemony within art theory, the uneven nature of sales and the volatility of the market itself, where tidal waves in New York ripple through places like St Louis without too much delay, make playing the market in contemporary art a very risky business. Plattner gives the example of the pop-art painting which, reproduced as a poster by a museum, was mistakenly sold at auction as a fine-art print to naively keen collectors for over \$13,000.

Since so many are unsure of what they are buying and since the possibility of losing money is so great, the importance of trust looms large in most transactions. And the best way of engendering trust, Plattner finds, is by embedding the sale within social relations: you are sold pictures by people whom you know, who get to know you or whose local reputation seems unassailable. As one dealer revealed: 'Now I grew up with this young boy, and so he was very open with me. He said, "But it's going to be about five or six months before I inherit my trust, so can we put the purchase off for six months?" I said, "Hey, you will be a great client of mine; you are willing to spend lots of money. I will bend over backwards for you."'

Plattner has an admirably clear style. The book is a pleasant read and it fills a gap in the ethnography of art markets. What is perhaps most surprising in his book is the sheer number of people prepared to become involved in this market, not because they necessarily like the pictures or objects they purchase or sell, but because they believe in or look up to the culture-expanding ideals of 'high' art. At times Plattner's ethnography reads as though what sustains this local market is not people's aesthetic enjoyment of the pictures but the pleasure they derive from participating in the maintenance of an ideology whose existence they approve of.

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SIGÜENZA OROZCO, SALVADOR. *Minería y comunidad indígena: el mineral de Natividad, Ixtlán,*